

The Freedom of Forgiveness

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Understanding, Processing, and Releasing Emotional Burdens

Author: Adam Fistler, BCH - Behavioral Change Consultant (adam@adamfistler.com)

What Is Forgiveness?

Forgiveness is often misunderstood. People sometimes hear the word and assume they are being asked to excuse harmful behavior, forget what happened, trust someone again, or invite that person back into their life. None of those things is required. Forgiveness is not approval, denial, reconciliation, or surrender. It is a personal process of acknowledging what happened, understanding its impact, learning what the experience can teach, and gradually releasing the emotional burden so the past has less control over the present.

Forgiveness Is a Process

When something painful happens, the mind naturally tries to make sense of it. It asks why it happened, what it means, how it could have been prevented, and what should happen next. When an experience is overwhelming or unresolved, the mind may return to it repeatedly. Anger and resentment can be attempts to keep processing an experience that still feels unfinished. The goal of forgiveness is not to force those feelings away. It is to give them attention, understanding, and a safe path toward resolution.

Processing begins with honest acknowledgment: I have looked at what happened. I recognize how it affected me. I can learn from it without allowing it to define me. When the lesson has been understood and the necessary boundaries are clear, I can begin deciding whether I am ready to release the burden.

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The Memory and the Pain

Forgiveness does not require forgetting. Memories are part of our life experience, and remembering can help us recognize patterns, protect ourselves, and make wiser choices. The goal is to change our relationship with the memory. We can retain the facts, the wisdom, and the boundaries without continuing to carry the same anger, resentment, hurt, or emotional pain.

Forgiveness keeps the wisdom and releases the weight.

The Cost of Holding On

Anger may initially feel protective. We may believe that staying angry will keep us alert, prevent us from being hurt again, or ensure that the other person does not “get away with it.” These reactions make sense as attempts at self-protection. Yet when the original event is over and the person is no longer actively harming us, the emotional wound can remain active inside us. The event happened once; reliving it through resentment can make us suffer it repeatedly.

A grudge can become emotional armor. Armor may provide a sense of safety, but it can also restrict movement and block peace. Releasing anger does not mean becoming defenseless. It means choosing protection that is more effective than continued suffering: clear boundaries, realistic expectations, wise decisions, and care for yourself.

Accountability and Forgiveness

Forgiveness and accountability are not opposites. We can acknowledge that someone was wrong, name the harm they caused, accept that their actions had consequences, and maintain distance or firm boundaries. Forgiveness does not say, “What happened was acceptable.” It says, “What happened mattered, but I choose not to let it continue controlling my emotional life.” Reconciliation is a separate decision and is never a requirement of forgiveness.

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Why Anger Can Feel Bigger Than the Event

Sometimes our reaction to a present situation seems larger than the situation itself. This can happen when a current event resembles an older experience of rejection, betrayal, abandonment, humiliation, neglect, or powerlessness. The present moment activates an emotional pattern formed earlier, so the reaction carries both today's pain and yesterday's unresolved pain.

Think of two instruments tuned to the same note. When one instrument sounds, the other begins to vibrate in response. Emotions can work similarly: a new experience can resonate with an old one. Recognizing this does not invalidate the current hurt. It helps us understand why the feeling may be so intense and gives us another place to begin healing.

A Guided Forgiveness Process

Use this process slowly. You do not need to complete it all at once, and you should not choose the most overwhelming experience for your first attempt. If the exercise brings up intense distress, pause, ground yourself, and seek support from a qualified professional or trusted group facilitator.

1. Identify the person or situation

Choose one situation that still carries emotional charge. Be specific. You might write: "I still feel pain when I think about..."

2. Describe what happened

Separate observable events from assumptions. Complete the sentence: "They hurt me when _____."

Then consider: What happened? What did I feel? What did I believe about myself? What did I believe about the other person? What did I need at the time that I did not receive?

3. Allow the emotion to be acknowledged

Name the feelings without judging them: anger, sadness, fear, shame, grief, disappointment, or betrayal.

Acknowledging an emotion is not the same as obeying it. The purpose is to recognize what is present so it can be understood rather than driven underground.

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4. Look for understanding without excusing harm

When you feel grounded, consider the larger context. What might the other person have been thinking or trying to meet? Were they acting from their own limitations, pain, beliefs, or history? Did they understand the impact of their actions? These questions are not invitations to excuse abuse or remove responsibility. Understanding simply gives the mind a fuller picture and can reduce the grip of unanswered questions.

5. Identify the lesson and the boundary

Ask what the experience has taught you about your needs, your values, and the relationships you want. What boundary is necessary now? What behavior will you no longer accept? What support do you need? Learning from the experience allows you to honor what happened without remaining trapped in it.

6. Decide whether you are ready to release the burden

Forgiveness is a choice, and readiness cannot be forced. You may be able to say: “I forgive you for the harm connected to this experience. I release the anger and pain I am ready to release. I keep the lesson, maintain the boundaries I need, and choose to move forward.” If those words feel premature, use a gentler statement: “I am willing to become open to healing when I am ready.”

Creating Emotional Freedom

Some people find it helpful to imagine an emotional connection between themselves and the person or event. Picture that connection as carrying anger, hurt, resentment, and unfinished emotion. Then imagine setting it down or releasing it—not because the other person was right, but because your freedom matters. You can remain connected to the wisdom of your experience without remaining emotionally bound to the person who caused the pain.

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After Forgiveness

After reflecting, notice what has changed. The change may be subtle. Ask yourself: What feels different? Which emotions are lighter? Which thoughts have shifted? What choices are now possible? What part of my life can receive more attention now that I am carrying less of this burden?

Forgiveness creates space: space for peace, growth, healthier relationships, new experiences, and a more compassionate view of yourself. It may also reveal grief or additional work that still needs attention. That does not mean the process failed. Healing is rarely linear, and forgiveness may need to be revisited more than once.

Group Reflection

For discussion, share only what feels safe and appropriate. You may pass at any time. Listen to understand rather than to fix, compare, or judge.

- What has forgiveness meant to you in the past?
- Which misconception about forgiveness has affected you most?
- What is the difference between releasing resentment and reconciling with someone?
- What lesson or boundary can you keep from a painful experience?
- What would emotional freedom look like in your life?

Closing Thought

Forgiveness is not weakness, surrender, or permission for someone to harm you again. It is the strength to look honestly at what happened, care for the parts of yourself that were hurt, learn what you need to learn, and decide how much power the past will have over your present. You cannot change the past, but you can change your relationship with it.

Understand the experience. Learn the lesson. Maintain your boundaries. Release the burden when you are ready. Choose freedom.

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About the Author

Adam Fistler is a Behavioral Change Consultant, Board Certified Hypnotist, Certified 5-PATH® Hypnotist, and former owner of the Baltimore Hypnosis Center. A member of the International 5-PATH® Hypnosis Association and certified by the National Guild of Hypnotists, Adam has studied hypnosis, behavior change, and the relationship between thoughts, beliefs, emotions, and behavior for more than two decades.

His perspective is shaped by both professional training and personal experience. Adam has lived through addiction and recovery, giving him an understanding of the struggle from both sides: as a practitioner who has helped others create change and as someone who has confronted deeply ingrained patterns and beliefs in his own life.

Today, Adam combines professional knowledge with lessons from his own journey to help people explore meaningful change. His approach is grounded in empathy, curiosity, practical tools, and the belief that people are more than the behaviors they are trying to overcome.

Important Note

This handout is educational and is not a substitute for medical care, licensed mental-health treatment, crisis support, or legal advice. Forgiveness should never be used to pressure someone to remain in an unsafe relationship, abandon necessary boundaries, or excuse abuse. If you are in immediate danger or experiencing a crisis, contact emergency services or an appropriate crisis resource.